



We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

There are truths  
about our future  
actions.

In the past, God  
had  
foreknowledge of  
our future  
actions.

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

We have no  
choice about the  
past.

Let's turn to our last line of response to the two arguments. This is to deny the assumption, common to both arguments, that we have no choice about the past.

The denial of this assumption is often associated with William of Ockham, an English philosopher and theologian who was born about 15 years after Aquinas' death, in 1288. (He's the one that "Ockham's razor" is named after.)





To see why this might not be ridiculous, consider the overlooked philosophical problem of the incompatibility of free will and roommate true belief.

It seems that sometimes, your roommate can have true beliefs about what you will do; for example, the following might be true:

At 10 am today, your roommate  
believed that you would eat a salad  
for lunch.

Now imagine that at noon you are in the dining hall, about to grab a salad, when you are suddenly overcome with an unlikely desire for a fish sandwich. Do you have a choice about whether you will choose the salad or the fish sandwich? It seems that you do. **But then it also seems that you have a choice about whether your roommate's belief, at 10 am, was true.** After all, if you had chosen the fish sandwich, your roommate's belief that you would eat a salad would have been false.

If this story makes sense, it follows that you do sometimes have a choice about past events: you had a choice about whether, in the past, a certain belief about your future actions was true.

Of course, this does not mean that you have a choice about **every** past fact. For example, you don't now have a choice about whether it rained yesterday. But consider the sorts of "past facts" at play in the Fatalist Argument.

They are facts like this:



In 2000 BC it was true that on  
6/1/2030 you will get married.

This is a fact about the past; but it is also partly about the future. It is perhaps not so hard to believe that you will have a choice in 2030 about whether in 2000 BC this was a fact.

So perhaps Ockham's strategy of saying that we have a choice about some past facts helps with the Fatalist Argument. Does it help with the Foreknowledge Argument?

The kind of past facts at play in that argument are facts like  
this one:

In 2000 BC God knew that on  
6/1/2030 you will get married.

Let's return to the example about you having a choice about whether your roommate's belief was true.

In that case, you had the power to make your roommate's  
belief true, or make the belief false.

Will you, by analogy, have the power to make God's belief  
about your future actions false?



Here the analogy appears to break down. God is (on standard views) infallible; it's impossible to make God make a mistake. So (if this is true) you couldn't have the power to make God's belief about your future actions false.

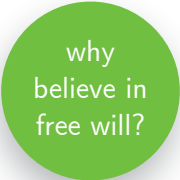
This does not show that this response to the Foreknowledge Argument fails. But it does show that we need some explanation of how it could be that in 2030 it could be up to you whether in 2000 BC God knew something.



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is fate  
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why  
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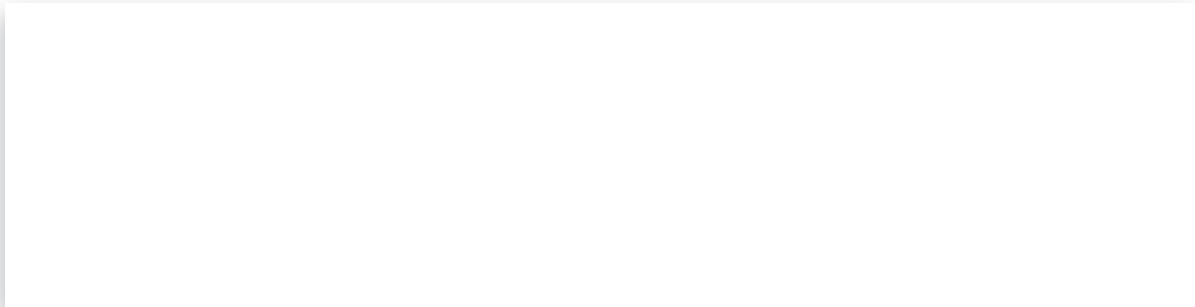
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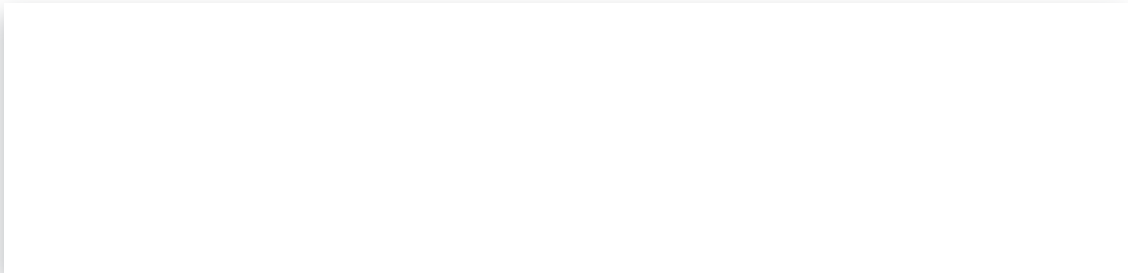


Fatalist Argument.

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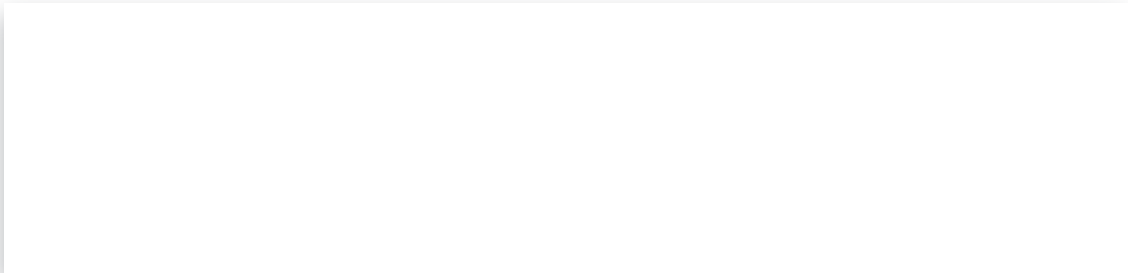
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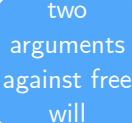
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Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But



that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predictor.

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,



Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Suppose that someone did not believe in

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

actions. Could they give an argument

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

similar to Edwards' argument?

there were truths about all our future



with reference to the being of truth about

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.



1. We have no direct facts.

all of our activities.



that if it is true that I will perform

3 We have not the fact that

2\* In the past, there were truths about

acaioid.

then we have the choice about q.

4. If we have no choice about  $p$ , and no

perform a certain action (1,2)

(3, 4, 5)



God knows that in the future I will



5\* We have not decided what the fact

some action, then I will prefer that

choice about the fact that if  $p$ , then  $q$ ,

0 We have achieved what we

will perform various actions.

The fatalist argument

































